

Bactrian camel

Camelus bactrianus



two toes on each
foot cushioned
by fatty pads

The Bactrian camel roams the dry, rocky plains and hills of Central Asia, especially the Gobi Desert of China and Mongolia, where vegetation is scarce. The two humps on its back store fat, which is converted to water and energy to sustain the camel during droughts. The humps shrink as the fat is used up.

Little is known about the Bactrian camel's behavior as it is difficult to study due to its nomadic lifestyle and remote habitat. It does not defend a territory, but lives in small herds that travel long distances in search of food. Mature breeding males spit at, bite, and kick rivals in battles. The strongest males gather a harem of females around them to mate with.

The Bactrian camel obtains most of the water it needs from its diet of leaves. It seldom sweats, to help conserve fluids during hot desert summers. However,

after a drought, when it finally reaches water, it can drink up to 36 gallons (135 liters) of water in just 15 minutes. It can also tolerate drinking much saltier water than domesticated camels can. The desert winters are bitterly cold, so the Bactrian camel grows a long, thick, woolly coat. The two broad toes on each foot spread out to prevent it from sinking in snow or sand.

Tamed existence

Fewer than 1,400 Bactrian camels remain in the wild and the population continues to decline, but the species is widely domesticated as a hardy transportation animal. Its relative, the one-humped dromedary, is now an entirely domesticated species found in North Africa, the Middle East, and Central Asia, and has been introduced to Australia.

- ↔ 11–12 ft (3.2–3.5 m)
- ⚖ 400–500 kg (880–1,100 lb)
- ⊗ Critically endangered
- 🌿 Herbs, shrubs
- 🏠 



C. Asia

